

school in Howrah had no real claim to glory and had more than its fair share of students for whom coming to school was a luxury—and environmental protection was an irrelevant concern. But then Subash Dutta, a chartered accountant by profession, always trod the path less travelled. And much later in life, when his unemployed father died, the trauma of being unable to properly carry out the last rites on the banks of the Ganga strengthened his resolve to fight against ecological degradation.

"After the rituals, I could not even take a bath in the river at the Telkaal ghat. It was so filthy that I decided then and there that I would take up this issue with the authorities," says Dutta, whose mission to save the river started in 1983. It was in 1977, moved by the problem of joblessness, that Dutta began the Ganatantrik Nagarik Samity and started his "career as a protestant, not by re-

surveys the affected areas himself. "I take pictures and talk to the locals. Only after assessing the situation do I write my petition. When I started my campaign against the Ganga pollution, I walked along the banks to find out exactly how dirty it was," he says. Thanks to Dutta, the people of Kolkata can enjoy the greenery of the Kolkata Maidan, the Victoria Memorial and the Rabindra Sarovar lake, which alone covers 7.77 lakh square metre, for some more years.

In his crusade against environmental pollution, Dutta was once arrested after being falsely implicated by a police officer. He has also been unfairly blamed for the removal of the annual book fair from the Maidan though he never wanted it. Does it hurt that he has often been criticised for his relentless fight to save the environment? "It does, but I am getting used to it," says the man who steers clear of political parties. And how does his family handle this man with a mission? Wife Swati, who used to get perplexed in the beginning, has, over the years, realised that her husband is not really someone who will care only about the family. She accepts it with a smile. His two children, son Sumanta and daughter Sayoni, are proud of their father's work. Sumanta, 24, is al-

ready a successful corporate working in Scotland, while Sayoni, a second-year BA student, is an aspiring model and actor.

From the slums of Howrah has risen a voice that is now heard all over the country. It's a voice that has forced the judiciary to take note of a number of environmental hazards. Today, Dutta is so well-known in the city that letters which carry just his name on the envelop reach his home in Howrah. But it's not enough. "I have risen from an environment where human suffering was a way of life. I wanted to change all that," he says. It was not a challenge for him, it was his way of survival. Today, he has a better life, something he would like to share with others. "I will fight as long as I can. I feel sad that I can't attend to even 10 per cent of the complaints I receive and people misunderstand me," he says. Yet, with his immense faith in the judiciary, Dutta believes he can leave behind a greener, cleaner Kolkata. ■

Having spent my childhood under miserable conditions, I am determined to stand up to wrongs committed by those in authority.

SUBASH DUTTA, Environmental activist



ligion but by practice". What started as a tiny voice against unemployment, soon became the common man's roar on civic problems.

Dutta has filed 67 PILs till now. He doesn't really keep an account of his legal expenses though he knows it has been a drain on his earnings. "I do get some sponsors from time to time, but mostly I try to manage my own expenses," he says. Most of the PILs deal with environmental issues, but he cherishes his fight to save the Ganga most. "That I could draw attention to the river which can be a lifeline for the city gives me immense satisfaction," he says. Dutta was instrumental in the formation of the environment bench, better known as the green bench in the Calcutta High Court in 1996—the first ever in the country. "I consider that to be one of my biggest achievements," says the affable gentleman, reading glasses perched on a sharp nose, scanning some documents needed for his pending cases.

Before filing his petitions, Dutta actually



SOURASH MALLICK